

HAM-FISTED

a board game of amateur radio, ego, and the never-ending net

"Get on the air. Survive the coffee. Don't key up during the net."

COMPLETE RULEBOOK & CARD REFERENCE

For 2–6 players · Ages 12+ · 60–90 minutes

1. Overview

Ham-Fisted is a path-and-cards game in the tradition of The Game of Life, reimagined around the very specific chaos of a small-town amateur radio club. You are 25 years old. You just passed your Technician exam. You have wandered, hopeful and underprepared, into a folding-table fiefdom ruled by seven men named Gary, all of whom insist their antenna is the best one.

Players race their peg-cars (antenna optional, but strongly encouraged) along a five-stage path representing a ham radio life: getting licensed, building a station, surviving the weekly net, navigating club politics, and finally, inevitably, becoming the grouchy old-timer yourself.

The game combines a Life-style spinner-and-path structure with a card-driven event system. There is very little you can strategize your way around — much like real club life, outcomes are mostly a matter of what Gary says to you this week.

2. Components

- 1 folding game board (5 connected stage-tracks: Foundry, Shack, Net, Repeater Wars, Elmer Status)
- 6 peg-cars with removable mag-mount antenna toppers
- 1 "Big Knob" spinner (1–6, standing in for a VFO tuning dial)
- 84 Event Cards across 5 decks (Foundry, Shack, Net, Repeater Wars, Elmer)
- Cred tokens (small, brass-colored, meant to resemble washers)
- Watts tokens (paper "money," denominations of 1, 5, and 10)
- 6 Player Mats (license class tracker, gear tracker, Cred/Watts tally)
- 1 rulebook (this document)
- Beard tokens, awarded upon reaching Elmer Status, for dramatic effect

3. Setup

- Each player picks a peg-car and Player Mat, and takes a starting kit: 5 Cred, 10 Watts, and a Technician-class marker.
- Shuffle each of the five Event Card decks separately and place them face-down on their marked spaces on the board.
- All peg-cars start at "The Foundry" space at the beginning of the track.
- Decide turn order by spinning the Big Knob — highest spin goes first (in the event of a tie, both players must argue about it for a while, then re-spin).

4. How to Play

4.1 Turn Sequence

- Spin the Big Knob (1–6) and move your peg-car that many spaces along the path.
- Resolve the space you land on (see Section 6, Board Spaces).
- If you land on or pass through a stage's Net-type space, resolve a Squelch Check (Section 5).
- Play passes clockwise to the next player.

4.2 Stages

The board is divided into five sequential stages. A player must fully complete one stage's track before advancing to the next. The stages, in order, are:

- The Foundry — getting licensed, buying your first cheap radio, learning you know nothing
- The Shack — building your station, fighting your antenna, fighting your HOA
- The Net — weekly check-ins, contests, on-air etiquette (and violations thereof)
- The Repeater Wars — club politics, coordinator disputes, decades-old feuds
- Elmer Status — becoming the person you once found insufferable

5. Currency: Cred and Watts

Ham-Fisted runs on two resources that rarely convert cleanly into one another — much like the real hobby.

5.1 Cred

Cred represents your standing and reputation within the club and on the air. It is spent to unlock privileges (like running net control, or being taken seriously in a Repeater Wars vote), to skip a mandatory-but-boring meeting space, or to silence a heckler card played against you (pay 2 Cred to negate one negative Net Card).

5.2 Watts

Watts represent your literal money — spent on gear upgrades, antennas, and the occasional HOA fine. You start with a \$30 handheld and a dream (10 Watts). Watts are gained through card effects, selling gear at the Swap Meet space, and the occasional stipend from club volunteer work.

5.3 The Squelch Check

Whenever you land on a Net space, you draw a Net Card and must "break squelch" by spinning the Big Knob. A spin of 4–6 succeeds: resolve the card's Effect normally. A spin of 1–3 means an old-timer talks over you — apply only negative effects from the card (or, if the card is positive, you simply lose a turn instead).

6. Board Spaces

In addition to each stage's numbered path spaces (which trigger that stage's Event Card deck), several special spaces appear throughout the board:

The Coffee Pot

Free space, no mechanical effect. You must listen to a story about 1987. This is non-optional and non-skippable in spirit.

Field Day

Mandatory group space. All players 'camp' together for one turn. Best generator setup gets +3 Cred. Forgetting sunscreen costs a turn.

The Silent Key

A somber space. Remove a peg from an opponent's memory (no penalty to them). Everyone is nice for one round.

FCC Violation

Draw a Violation sub-card: 60% nothing happens, 30% small fine (-3 Watts), 10% someone reports you for doubling on the net (-4 Cred).

Swap Meet

Trade any one Watts-cost item with another player, or sell a piece of gear back to the bank for half its Watts value.

Elmer Status

The final space of each stage's track. Reaching it in the fifth stage with enough Cred and an Extra Class license wins the game.

7. Event Card Decks

Below is the complete reference for every card in the game, organized by deck. When a card's Effect references Cred or Watts, apply it immediately unless the card text says otherwise.

7.1 Foundry Deck (16 cards)

Card	What Happens	Effect
Technician Pass	You passed your Technician exam on the first try. A club member mutters 'back in my day it was harder.'	+2 Cred
General Upgrade	You upgraded to General class. The Elmers grudgingly nod.	+3 Cred
The Baofeng	You bought a UV-5R for \$28. A member calls it 'a toy' loudly enough for the whole room.	-1 Cred, +1 Watt
Correct Programming	You programmed your radio's memory channels correctly on the first try. Everyone is suspicious.	+2 Cred
Callsign Envy	You get a decent 2x3 callsign in the vanity lottery. A Gary wanted that one.	+2 Cred
Study Group No-Show	You skip the VE test prep session to work a double shift. Nobody notices you weren't there. You still pass.	No effect
The Manual	You actually read the ARRL Handbook cover to cover. You now understand roughly 40% of what Gary #3 says.	+1 Cred
Field Strength Meter	You buy a cheap SWR meter and immediately misuse it.	-2 Watts
License Plate	You get a ham radio license plate before you've made a single contact. This is	-1 Cred

Card	What Happens	Effect
	considered premature.	
Extra Class Attempt	You attempt the Extra exam early out of spite. You fail the math section.	-1 Cred, lose a turn
Hand-Me-Down Rig	A retiring member gives you his old Kenwood 'because you seem serious about this.'	+3 Watts, +2 Cred
The Wrong Antenna	You buy a CB antenna by mistake and mount it before anyone stops you.	-2 Cred
First QSO	You make your very first contact. Your hands are shaking. It goes fine.	+2 Cred
License Framed	You frame your license and hang it in the shack. This is either endearing or deeply unserious, depending who you ask.	No effect
Overheard Advice	An Elmer explains grounding to you for eleven straight minutes. You retain none of it, but you nod a lot.	+1 Cred
Cheap Coax	You run 100 feet of the cheapest coax you could find. Your signal report reflects this.	-2 Watts

7.2 Shack Deck (16 cards)

Card	What Happens	Effect
Antenna Too Short	Your antenna is 'too short' according to Gary #3. He will explain optimal element length for the rest of the meeting.	Lose a turn
The Dipole Kit	You build your own dipole from a kit and it actually resonates.	+4 Cred, +1 Watt
HOA Letter	Your HOA sends a strongly worded letter about your antenna's 'visual impact.'	-5 Watts or remove your antenna upgrade
Ground Rod Day	You spend an entire Saturday pounding ground rods. Your back will never be the same. Your noise floor drops beautifully.	+3 Cred
Mystery RF	Your neighbor's baby monitor picks up your transmissions. This is now a whole conversation with the HOA.	-3 Cred
Attic Antenna	You sneak an antenna into your attic. Nobody outside can see it. You feel like a spy.	+2 Cred, +1 Watt
Tower Envy	A club member's 60-foot tower goes up next door to your apartment complex. You will never compete with this. Stop trying.	No effect
Shack Flood	A pipe bursts near your shack. Your logbook survives. Your rig does not.	-4 Watts
Homebrew Success	You build a working antenna tuner from scrap parts and a coffee can, literally.	+3 Cred
The Linear Amp	You buy a used linear amplifier off a swap net. It works, but it hums ominously.	-6 Watts, +2 Cred
Wire Everywhere	You string wire antennas through three trees in your yard. Your spouse/roommate has Opinions.	+2 Cred, -1 Watt
Static Discharge	You forget to disconnect your antenna during a thunderstorm. Nothing bad happens, but three people lecture you about it anyway.	-1 Cred
Solder Fumes	You spend a weekend building a kit radio. It works on the third try.	+3 Cred
Borrowed Rotor	You borrow an antenna rotor from a club member who will remind you about it at every meeting until you return it.	+1 Watt, lose 1 Cred per future Shack space until returned
Perfect SWR	You get a 1.1:1 SWR reading on the first tune. A small crowd gathers to witness this miracle.	+3 Cred
The J-Pole	You build a J-pole out of PVC pipe and copper wire for under \$15. It outperforms rigs ten times its price.	+4 Cred, +1 Watt

7.3 Net Deck (16 cards)

Remember: cards drawn on Net spaces require a Squelch Check spin before resolving (Section 5.3).

Card	What Happens	Effect
Wrong Sign-Off	You said 'over and out.' This is not correct procedure and everyone on frequency knows it.	-2 Cred
DX Contact	You work a station in Antarctica during a rare activation. Two Elmers now respect you, reluctantly.	+5 Cred
Mystery RF Bleed	Someone's rig is bleeding RF into the whole net. It's not you. Everyone assumes it's you anyway.	-1 Cred
Good Signal Report	You get a 5x9 report from a station 800 miles away on 5 watts.	+3 Cred
Doubling	You key up at the exact same moment as another station. The resulting noise offends everyone's ears.	Lose a turn
Net Control	You're asked to run net control for the evening. You do a surprisingly good job.	+4 Cred
Phonetic Fumble	You use 'A as in Apple' instead of proper phonetics. A retired military member visibly flinches.	-1 Cred
Rare Grid Square	You activate a rare grid square during a contest. Your callsign gets spotted on three cluster networks.	+4 Cred
Dead Air	You forget to unmute and talk for thirty seconds to absolute silence. Someone finally says 'you're not keyed up, dear.'	-2 Cred
Late Check-In	You check into the weekly net five minutes late during roll call. Net control makes a Comment.	-1 Cred
Emergency Drill	You participate in a simulated emergency net and actually follow proper traffic-handling procedure.	+3 Cred
The Ragchew	You get pulled into a forty-five minute conversation about someone's gutter repair. You cannot politely exit.	Lose a turn
Contest Weekend	You stay up until 3am chasing contacts for a contest. You gain a callsign notch and a caffeine dependency.	+3 Cred, -1 Watt
Kerchunking	You accidentally key up the repeater without saying anything, twice. A voice sighs: 'kerchunker.'	-2 Cred
New Voice Welcome	An Elmer actually welcomes you warmly on air and explains local nets to you without condescension. It happens sometimes.	+2 Cred
Split Frequency Confusion	You call a DX station on their transmit frequency instead of listening frequency. A pileup of groans ensues.	-2 Cred

7.4 Repeater Wars Deck (16 cards)

Card	What Happens	Effect
Schedule Change Proposal	You suggest changing the net time to accommodate people with actual jobs. This does not go over well.	-3 Cred
Repeater Repair	You volunteer to fix the club's ancient repeater controller. It works better than it has in a decade.	+6 Cred, +2 Watts
CW vs Real Radio	A feud breaks out over whether CW is 'real radio.' You are forced to pick a side.	-1 Cred (either side)
Coordinator Dispute	Two members argue for forty minutes about frequency coordination paperwork from 1994.	Lose a turn
New Blood Committee	You're voted onto the 'attracting younger members' committee. You are the only person under 50 on it, including yourself as the sole example.	+2 Cred
Digital Modes Uprising	You champion adding FT8 and digital modes to club activities. Half the club calls it 'not real radio.' The other half quietly agrees with you.	+3 Cred, -2 Cred from one faction (net +1)
Bylaws Meeting	A three-hour meeting is held to amend one sentence of the club bylaws. Nothing is resolved.	Lose a turn
Repeater Trustee Election	You run for repeater trustee against a man who has held the position since 1988.	Spin again: win = +5 Cred, lose = -2 Cred
Budget Surplus	The club has unexpected surplus funds from dues. You propose a new antenna. It's approved.	+4 Watts
Silent Feud	Two members haven't spoken since a 2003 disagreement about tower permits. You get triangulated into it.	-2 Cred
New Member Drive Success	Your outreach idea actually brings in three new members. You're a hero for exactly one meeting.	+5 Cred
The Coffee Fund Scandal	Someone is accused of skimming the coffee fund. It is nine dollars. This will be discussed for months.	No effect, lose a turn listening
Club Callsign Custody	You're granted trustee status of the club callsign. This is a bigger deal than it sounds.	+4 Cred
Antenna Farm Vote	The club votes on where to place a shared antenna farm. You lobby hard for a good site.	Spin: even = +3 Cred, odd = -1 Cred
Newsletter Editor	You accidentally volunteer to edit the club newsletter by asking one clarifying question during a meeting.	+2 Cred per turn while held, -1 Watt (ink)
The Generational Handoff	An old-timer quietly hands you the keys to the repeater site 'because someone needs to keep doing this after we're gone.'	+6 Cred

7.5 Elmer Deck (5 cards)

This short deck is only shuffled in once a player enters the final stage of the board.

Card	What Happens	Effect
You Explain Grounding	You catch yourself explaining proper grounding technique to a new member for eleven straight minutes.	+2 Cred
The New Kid	A 24-year-old shows up with a Baofeng and asks a basic question. You almost call it 'a toy.' You don't. Growth.	+3 Cred
Elmer of the Year	You're nominated for the club's mentor award for actually being nice to new hams.	+5 Cred
Grouch Relapse	Someone asks why the net starts at 7pm sharp and you deliver a monologue nobody asked for.	-1 Cred (worth it)
Field Day Legend	Your generator setup becomes the stuff of club legend. People bring it up for years.	+4 Cred

8. Winning the Game: Reaching Elmer Status

Unlike classic Life, there is no simple "retirement" — you don't win by reaching the end of the track alone. To win, a player must reach the Elmer Status space at the end of the fifth stage while meeting all three conditions:

- At least 20 Cred banked
- An Extra Class license marker (earned via a Foundry or Repeater Wars card, or purchased for 8 Watts at any Swap Meet space)
- At least one completed Field Day space without losing a turn to sunburn or a bad generator roll

The first player to satisfy all three conditions immediately wins. Flip your peg-car's antenna topper to the "beard" side, take a Beard token, and begin heckling the next new 25-year-old who wanders in — that is, the other players, for the remainder of the session, informally and at no game-mechanical cost.

If two or more players would satisfy all three conditions on the same turn, the player with the higher Cred total wins. If still tied, both players must argue about who really "builds their own gear" until a winner emerges by attrition.

9. Variant Rules

9.1 Two-Player "Elmer & Newcomer"

One player plays a veteran starting at the Shack stage with 15 Cred and an Extra Class marker; the other starts fresh at the Foundry. This recreates the lopsided but oddly endearing dynamic of a single mentor relationship rather than a full club.

9.2 Short Game

Remove the Repeater Wars stage entirely and proceed straight from The Net to Elmer Status. Recommended for a 30–40 minute session or a group with limited patience for club politics, fictional or otherwise.

9.3 Ironman Net

Every Squelch Check is resolved at a 5–6 success threshold instead of 4–6. Recommended only for masochists and people who genuinely enjoy losing turns.

10. Quick Reference / Player Aid

- Turn: Spin → Move → Resolve space → (Net space: Squelch Check) → pass turn
- Squelch Check: spin 4–6 = success, resolve card fully. Spin 1–3 = talked over, apply negatives only / lose a turn
- Pay 2 Cred to negate one negative Net Card effect
- Win: reach Elmer Status with 20+ Cred, Extra Class marker, and 1+ completed Field Day
- The Coffee Pot has no mechanical effect. This is intentional.

73, and good luck out there.